

His 5 big MISSTEPS

BHASKAR PAUL

1 THE COMPANY HE KEEPS

In the run up to E-2009, he was busy meeting top industrialists like Sunil Bharti Mittal, Anil and Mukesh Ambani to discuss the state of the economy, instead of finalising election strategies with his party colleagues.

2 MISREADING MESSAGE

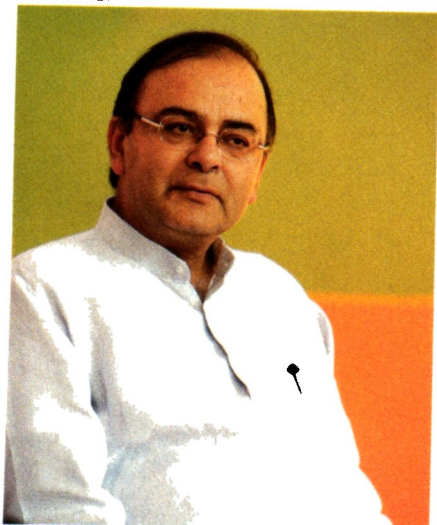
Having done the right thing by quitting in the wake of 2009 election results, Advani missed his great chance of an honourable exit when he allowed himself to be "persuaded" by his cynical coterie to hang on.

leader who refuses to accept his own redundancy. Once upon a time, there was an Advani the mobiliser who travelled the entire length of the country as the spokesman of a vandalised nation. He retrieved the abandoned gods of the political Hindu from the archival sites of civilisation and placed them just outside the polling booths. He was the argumentative nationalist who provided the sharpest counterpoints to the official version of secularism. He made the BJP a party of governance, which marked a historic right turn in Indian politics. The best of Advani, whose political career is almost as old as independent India, embodied struggle against power. That Advani is long dead. What we have today is a grim old man who is desperately struggling to postpone his own political irrelevancy. Out there, as the banished and the sidelined ask questions about his leadership, his integrity and honesty, his lies and tricks, he has no words to defend himself. The iron cult is being blasted.

Along with him, the party too is unravelling. Since the fall in 2004, which itself was precipitated by the blinding fallacy of a "shining" slogan, it has been a story

of slow but steady disintegration. Once a party that was pretty certain of its ideological identity, the BJP today is a house of delusion, inhabited by leaders who are gifted with ambition but no ideas. Once the party that brought an end to the Congress century and challenged the dead certainties of left-liberal politics, it has wilfully vacated its rightful space in Indian politics. In retrospect, the-Right-in-power was the shortest romance in our political history; those who won the mandate proved not to be worthy of it. Today, after two devastating humiliations, the official custodians of the party are busy scavenging the wreckage of defeat for the last remains of power. It is the pathology of the discredited; and Advani, the BJP's tallest leader after Atal Bihari Vajpayee's retirement from active politics, is the cause number one. You just can't miss the irony. For so long, as Vajpayee soared above the party, Advani was the proverbial number two, and the long distance *yatri* of Indian politics never revealed his frustration. The more he travelled, the more elusive appeared the destination. When he did finally become number

HEMANT CHAWLA



SIPRA DAS



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ARUN JAITLEY, VENKAIAH NAIDU AND ANANTH KUMAR ARE ADVANI'S PROTEGES